Sussex League Cup match. I promise I am not making this up, but he was playing for – who else? – Shooters Hill CC.

Shooting is rather like batting: the younger you begin, the better chance you have of mastering its technicalities. It is not strictly dependent on hand–eye co-ordination; one of the most accurate shots I know is aged eighty-one. He's blind in his dominant eye, which forces him to lean over in the act of pulling the trigger. He struggles to walk. He has honed his skill since the age of fifteen.

I have been lucky over the last few years to spend some time with Beefy Botham, sharing our love for countryside sports near his home in North Yorkshire.

Similar interests, and shared experiences, can span the generations. I wasn't born when Beefy became a national hero during the 1981 Ashes, but, growing up, I became intrigued by his legend. He seemed such a compelling, devil-may-care character. My first real memory of him is from the 1992 World Cup, where he was a pinch-hitting opening bat as England lost to Pakistan in the final.

I know him as a very proud man, with a strong but thoughtful personality. He invited me to join him on a shoot about four years ago. We've had dinner together each summer and get on well socially. It is an extension of the dressing-room experience, where contrasting characters who might never have met without their sporting talent become unlikely friends.

He has mellowed slightly, but you can still see glimpses of the cricketer who transcended the game with his antics and achievements. We are bonded by our love of the countryside, but to make the connection with him I had to lose the insularity I'd developed as a player. I've learned that if you spread your wings, open yourself to new friendships and experiences, you can surprise yourself.

I don't have Beefy's aptitude for fishing, but I value his cricketing insight and admire his philosophy towards life. He's interested in farming, and we discuss the changing nature of the countryside. Traffic is increasing, water tables are shifting. I look at a field differently from how I looked at one ten years ago.

I don't know as much about the arable side of farming, but I'm intrigued by what might be happening beneath the surface. I'll glance momentarily over hedges as I am driving, working out what the farmer is doing, and how